

Q What's the procedure for CVS and how long will it take?

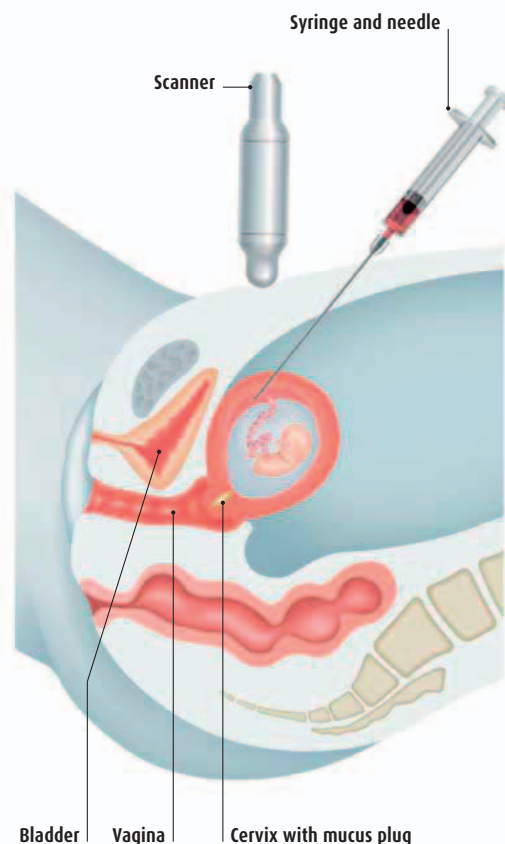
Chorionic villus sampling (CVS) is performed at 11 to 15 weeks to check your baby for certain disorders and abnormalities. The test is offered in pregnancies where a screening test shows there is a high risk of the baby having a condition.

Your doctor will remove the villi sample either by inserting a syringe needle through your abdomen into your placenta, or by inserting a tube via your vagina and entering your uterus through your cervix. In the latter case, a small amount of suction is passed through the tube to remove some villi from the placenta. The procedure your doctor uses will depend upon the position of your baby and the placenta.

You will be asked to go to your appointment with a full bladder, since you will need to have an ultrasound first to establish the position of the placenta in your uterus, and then to guide the doctor as he or she

takes the villi sample, (although in some circumstances your placenta may be positioned in such a way that you need to empty your bladder before the test continues). Including preparation, the whole procedure should take no more than 30 minutes, of which removing the villi will take only five to 10 minutes. The villi are then sent for testing. Your doctor will check your baby's movement and heartbeat after the procedure to make as sure as possible that all remains well.

Having the test A minute sample is taken from the placenta using a syringe with a long needle.



Before you decide to have the test, the possible risks will be discussed with you and your partner.

Q What's the procedure for amniocentesis and how long will it take?

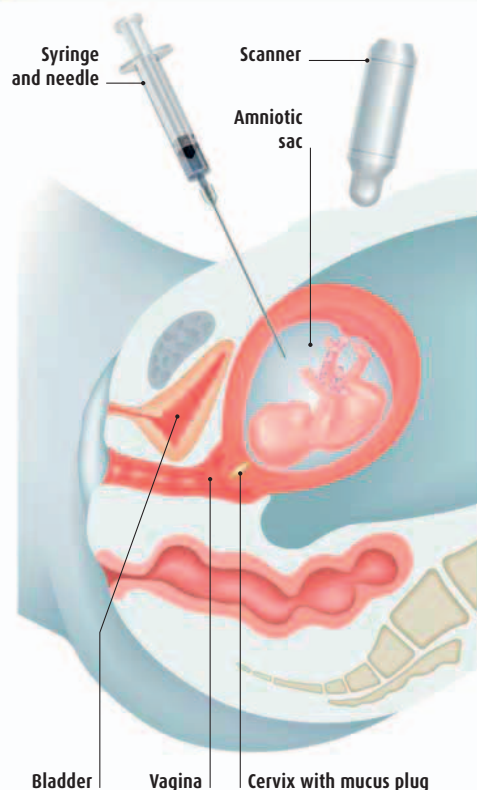
Offered to pregnant women from 14 weeks, this is another invasive diagnostic test. As with any diagnostic test, careful consideration needs to be given as to whether you need it and the result you might be given.

At the beginning of the procedure, your doctor will use an ultrasound to determine the position of your baby, your placenta, and the umbilical cord. He or she will then insert a needle with a syringe attached into your abdomen, through the wall of your uterus, and into your amniotic sac. The goal will be to draw out around $\frac{3}{4}$ fl oz (20ml) of fluid with the syringe. Amniotic fluid contains cells from your baby's skin, and these cells

contain DNA, which reveals details about your baby's genetic makeup. The fluid is then sent away for testing.

As with CVS, you'll need a full bladder so that your doctor can get a good ultrasound picture. (If you're more than 20 weeks pregnant, you may be asked to have an empty bladder.) Once the procedure is over, the doctor will also check your baby's movements.

The whole procedure should take 20 to 30 minutes. If your doctor doesn't draw enough in the first instance (this happens in around 8 percent of cases), he or she will reinsert the needle and take some more fluid.



Having the test Guided by the ultrasound probe, a needle is inserted to remove a small amount of amniotic fluid.